

TRUSTMRR · 1,000 LIVE STARTUPS

Where is startup value actually being created today?

A field study of 1,000 live, revenue-generating startups — what they built, who they sold to, and what the market actually rewarded.

A McKinsey-style read of the TrustMRR dataset

WHY IT MATTERS

**Founders are choosing categories.
Investors are pricing them.
Both are guessing.**

1

Founders

Pick a category because it feels hot — and inherit its crowding, its noise, and its odds, whether or not those odds are actually good.

2

Investors

Pay a premium for a category label at the term sheet or the exit table, assuming the label is doing the work that diligence should be doing.

3

Operators

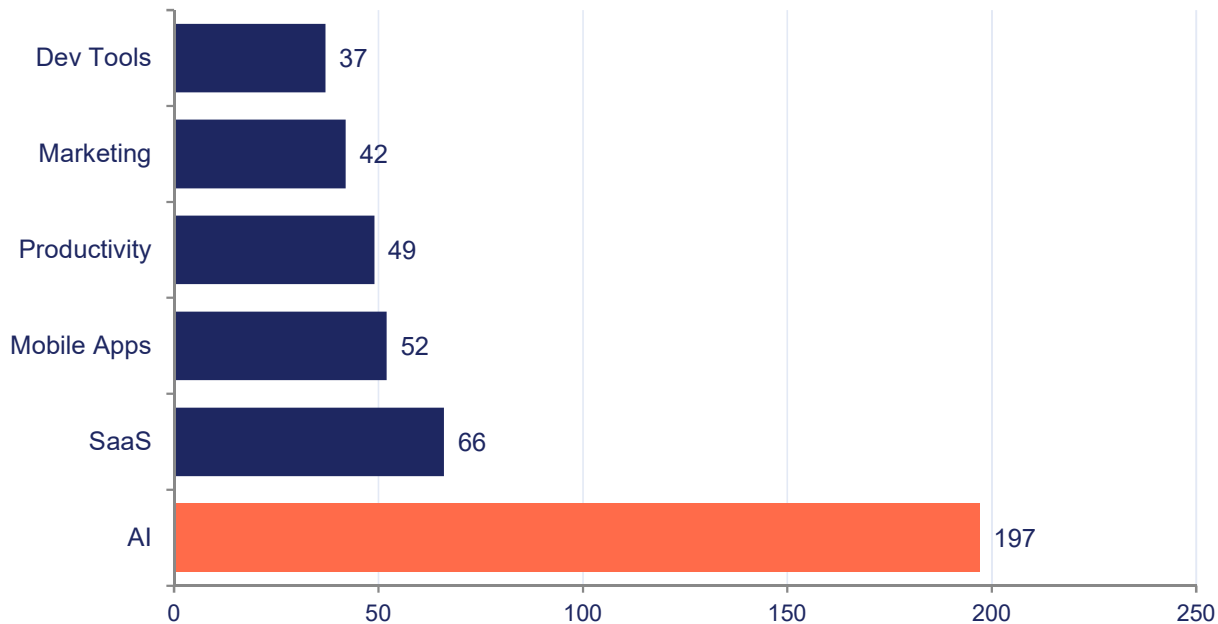
Benchmark growth and pricing against 'the market' without knowing which slice of the market they actually resemble.

That guess has a real price. This dataset lets us check it against 1,000 real outcomes.

CLUE NO. 1

One category swallowed the market

Of every startup in this dataset with a disclosed category, more than one in four is building in AI — more than the next three categories combined.



27.1%

of all named startups in the dataset are building in AI
— 197 of 726

197 > 167

AI alone out-numbers SaaS + Mobile Apps + Productivity
combined (66 + 52 + 49)

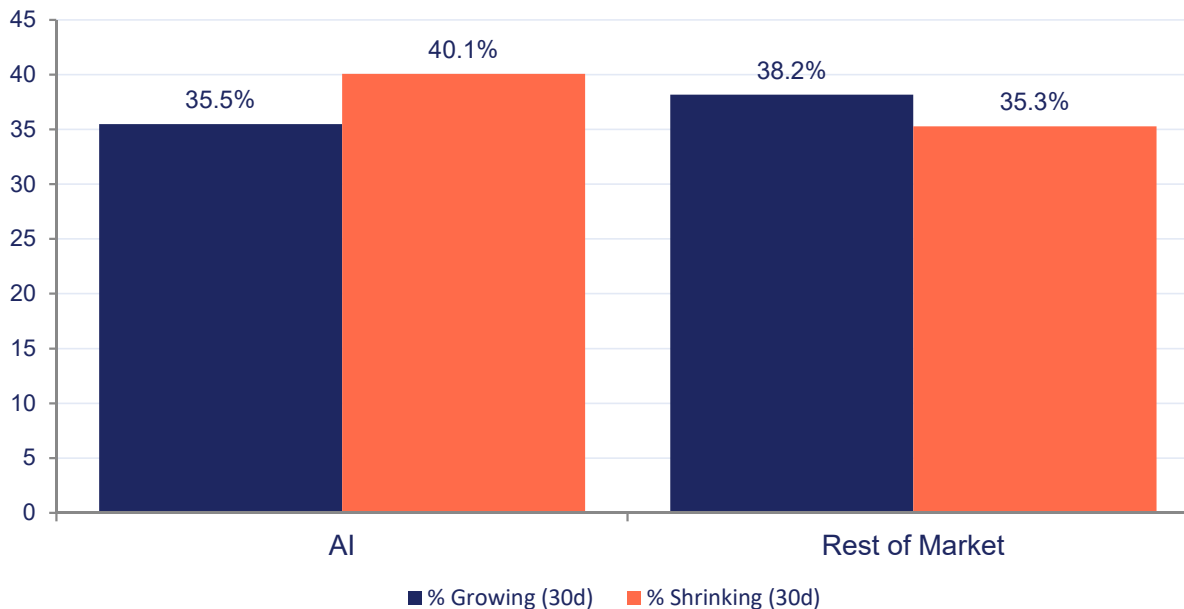
But does building where everyone else is building actually make a company stronger?

Source: TrustMRR dataset, 726 startups with disclosed category (of 1,000 total), frozen 30 Jul 2026

DIGGING DEEPER

The crowd arrived before the advantage did

If AI were genuinely outperforming, that scale would show up in the growth numbers. It doesn't — AI startups are actually a little more likely to be shrinking than growing.



40% > 36%

More AI startups shrank last month than grew — a worse growth mix than the rest of the market

\$4.3K vs \$3.2K

Median 12-month revenue: AI's edge over the rest of the market is real, but modest — not the gap the crowding implies

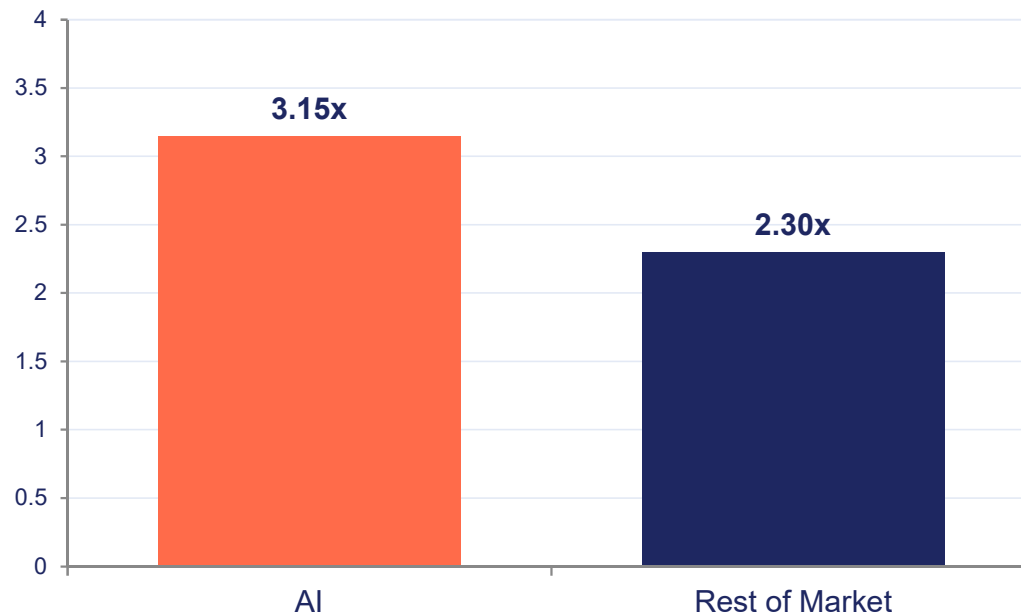
If the fundamentals aren't clearly better, why does the market keep treating AI as if they are?

Source: TrustMRR dataset, 726 startups with disclosed category (of 1,000 total), frozen 30 Jul 2026

CHALLENGING THE ASSUMPTION

The market still pays an “AI tax” at the exit door

Among startups listed for sale, AI businesses command a 37% higher revenue multiple than the rest of the market — even though their operating performance, slide over slide, doesn't clearly justify it.



+37%

premium buyers pay for the AI label at acquisition, based on 209 listed-for-sale companies

$r = 0.30$

Even audience size (X followers) only weakly predicts revenue — attention isn't the signal either

If the category label isn't the real signal — and neither is attention — what is?

Source: TrustMRR dataset, 726 startups with disclosed category (of 1,000 total), frozen 30 Jul 2026

CONNECTING THE DOTS

The real divide was never the category — it's the customer

Category label: weak signal. Follower count: weak signal. One variable in this dataset separates winners from the rest cleanly and consistently — who the startup sells to.

RULED OUT

Category

AI vs. everyone else showed only a modest revenue gap — and a worse growth mix.

RULED OUT

Attention

Follower count only weakly tracks revenue ($r = 0.30$) — and 185 startups with zero followers still out-earned the bottom half of the market.

THE SIGNAL

Who they sell to

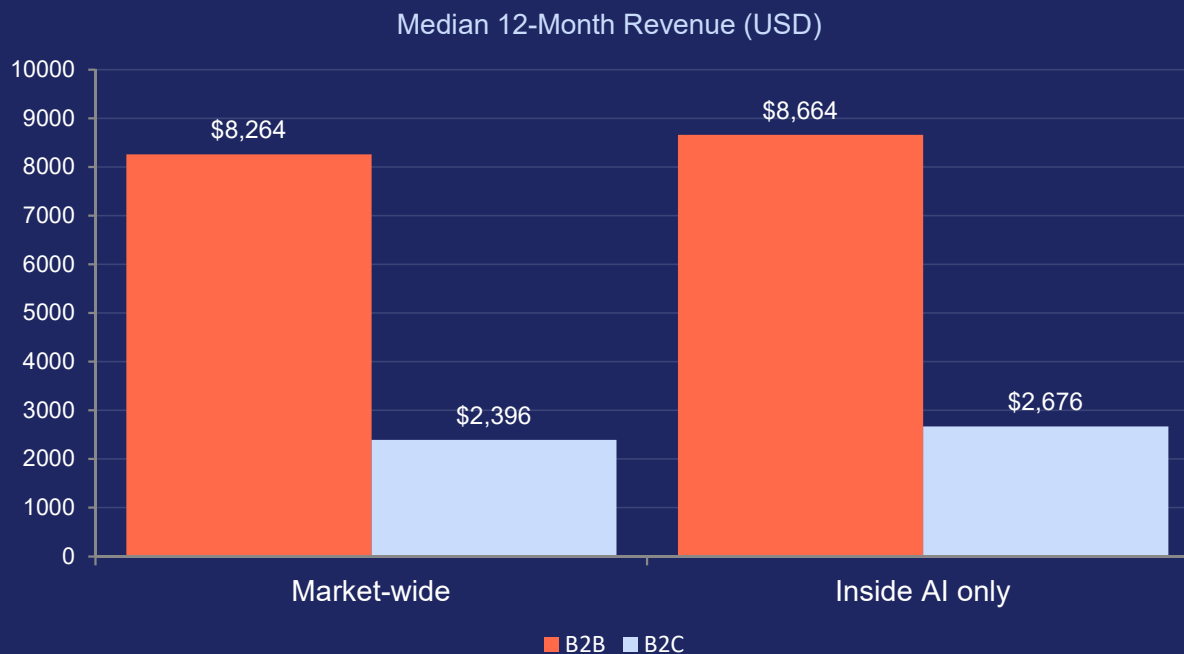
B2B vs. B2C splits the whole dataset into two very different outcome distributions — across every category, including AI.

How big is that gap, exactly?

THE TURNING POINT

B2B beats B2C by 3–6x — and the gap survives inside AI itself

Business-facing startups out-earn consumer-facing ones by a wide, repeatable margin — and the same 3x gap reappears when you isolate AI alone, proving it isn't a category effect.



3.4x

higher median revenue for B2B vs. B2C, market-wide
(\$8,264 vs. \$2,396)

5.7x

higher median MRR for B2B vs. B2C (\$1,034 vs. \$183) —
an even wider gap than revenue

WHAT THIS MEANS

If you were building or backing a company today, what would change?



For Founders

Choose the customer before the category.

A B2B product in a 'boring' category outsells a B2C product in the hottest one, 3-to-1. Building for AI doesn't buy you an edge — building for a business buyer does.



For Investors

Underwrite the audience, not the label.

A 37% AI acquisition premium isn't backed by a clear performance edge. Audience type is the more reliable revenue predictor in this dataset — diligence it like one.



For Operators

Benchmark against your real peer set.

'The market' isn't one distribution. A B2C AI company benchmarking against B2B peers is comparing itself to a business three times its size for no structural reason.

ZOOMING OUT

Hype cycles always outrun fundamentals — this one is no different

Every gold rush category — mobile apps, e-commerce, and now AI — goes through the same sequence. This dataset is a snapshot of a market still mid-repricing.



The founders and investors who win the next stretch won't be the ones who called the category first — they'll be the ones who priced the customer correctly while everyone else was still pricing the label.

THE FINAL VERDICT

Build for the customer. The category will catch up — or it won't.

B2B startups out-earn B2C ones by 3–6x, in every category and inside AI itself — while the market still pays a 37% premium for the AI label that the fundamentals haven't earned yet.

27.1%

of startups are in AI

3.4x

B2B revenue premium

+37%

AI acquisition premium

Source: TrustMRR dataset, 726 startups with disclosed category (of 1,000 total), frozen 30 Jul 2026